

A Changing Bronx

Warm-up:

Examine the various [maps of the Bronx](#).

- List 3 ways the Bronx has changed over time.
- Looking at the last map, which neighborhood do you live in?

Activity:

[Video Clip: American Experience New York](#)

Episode 4: 34:25 - 43:35

-Clip shows the wave of immigration from the late 1800s/early 1900s

-Discuss how crowded/ slum/tenement conditions in Manhattan + new subway system in 1904 = outer boroughs becoming haven for working class immigrants

[Gallery Walk - The Bronx \(1940s-50s\)](#)

I see... I think... I wonder... post-its

Gallery Walk Debrief:

A. Choose one image to describe. Why did this image stand out to you? What can it tell us about the Bronx?

B. What story do these images tell about the Bronx?

C. How did the Bronx change from its early years to the 1950s?

Text:

[“East Tremont” excerpt from *The Power Broker* by Robert Caro](#)

-Read as a class, highlight and annotate.

After reading Questions:

1. How does the author describe East Tremont? What kind of picture does Caro paint?
2. Going back to our discussions from the beginning of the year, would you say this community had power? Why or why not?

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A Changing Bronx

Warm-up: [Map Examination](#)

Examine the various maps of the Bronx.

1. List 3 ways the Bronx has changed over time.



2. Looking at the last map, which neighborhood do you live in?
What can the neighborhood names tell us about power in the Bronx?

Video Clip: Documentary

"The American Experience: New York: The Power & The People"

NOTES

Name: _____

Gallery Walk Debrief:

With your group, answer the following questions.

A. Choose one image to describe. Why did this image stand out to you? What can it tell us about the Bronx?

B. What story do these images tell about the Bronx?

The story told by these images is that in the 1930s-50s the Bronx was is that it was very populated, and had a lot of fun stuff. The community seemed clean and there were white families, Black families, Brown families, groups of women etc. Everyone seemed to dress very formally. Families seemed large and happy.

La historia que cuentan estas imágenes es que en las décadas de 1930 y 1950 el Bronx estaba muy poblado y tenía muchas cosas divertidas. La comunidad parecía limpia y había familias blancas, familias de color, grupos de mujeres, etc. Todos parecían vestirse muy formalmente. Las familias parecían numerosas y felices.

C. How did the Bronx change from its early years to the 1950s? How did the population shift?

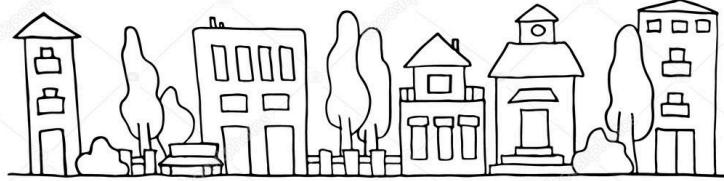
Name: _____

Text:

“East Tremont”

Excerpted from *The Power Broker*

By Robert Caro



Excerpt	Annotations
In the 1950s, the people of East Tremont did not have much. Jewish refugees or the children of refugees had come to New York to escape the ghettos of Eastern Europe. They had first settled in America on the Lower East Side. Although the slums of the Lower East Side housed their family and friends, they ached to escape the damp and squalid tenements, if not for their own sake, then for the sake of their children. Jews from the Lower East Side who had enough money to escape moved Central Park West. Jews who made enough money to escape - but not that much - moved to the Grand Concourse. The Jews of East Tremont were luckier than those who had to stay behind on the Lower East Side, but not so lucky as the Grand Concourse Jews. These were the pressers, finishers and cutters who worked in the bare workrooms in the garment factories. They were a long way from being rich and their neighborhood proved it. There were no elevators in most of the five and six story buildings into which they began to flood. By the 1950s the buildings' iron pipes were corroding causing leaks. With some 60,000 persons living along its narrow streets, its "population density" - 441 persons "per residential acre" - was considered "undesirable" by government officials. "In moving through East Tremont one senses a feeling of crowdedness brought on by the lack of open space and close locations of buildings," one wrote. But the neighborhood provided residents with things that were important to them. Transportation was important to the fathers who worked downtown, and the neighborhood had a good subway line that connected East	

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Tremont to the downtown garment district in Manhattan. Jobs were important to those who didn't work downtown and the community had good jobs available.

Shopping was important to the mothers who stayed home and took care of the kids, and the neighborhood was filled with local mom-and-pop shops of all kinds. Bakeries, vegetable stands, department stores, butcher shops were all located within walking distance.

Parks were important too. Running throughout was Southern Boulevard, whose broad center mall had grass plots plenty big enough for little children to play on, surrounded by benches so mothers could keep their eyes on them. And the southwest border of the neighborhood was Crotona Park. One mother described it as: "Beautiful. Lovely. Playgrounds. Baseball diamonds. Basketball hoops. There was a big swimming pool and a lake. Nice. We used to sit there - under the trees. We raised our children in Crotona Park."

And thanks to Tremont Avenue, you didn't have to leave the neighborhood for entertainment. There were seven movie houses. The Bronx Zoo was one stop away and the NY Botanical Gardens was three.

Government officials, who had never lived on the Lower East Side, might consider East Tremont "crowded." The people of East Tremont, who had, considered it open and airy, wonderfully open and airy.

To the people of East Tremont, East Tremont was family. In its bricks were generations. Raised in the neighborhood. Whole families lived in the same buildings. Lillian Roberts married a boy from the neighborhood and moved into an apartment on the third floor of 845 West 176th street. On the first floor of that building, Lillian's mother, originally from Russia, lived with Lillian's grandmother. On the second floor lived her sister and her family. East Tremont was friends- not just acquaintances you happened to meet on your block, but friends whom you had grown up with and were going to grow old with, boys and girls- turned men and women-who knew and understood you.

"Everyone seemed to help one another. If there was trouble, everyone would do something for you if they could. They were

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always coming in and sharing what they had,” said one resident. The apartments might have been a little shabby, but the rooms were large and the ceilings were high. “We all loved our apartments.”

They loved them -and they could afford them. Rent control kept apartment rates low. Lillian Roberts paid \$62 a month for her four room apartment. Cele Cohen had a six-room apartment- three bedrooms, a living room, kitchen and large dining room- and that apartment was \$69 a month.

The rents had to be reasonable for these people to afford them. Weekly take-home pay in the garment industry was well under a hundred dollars. The rents they were paying- low as they were-were, in many cases, the absolute maximum they could afford.

Waves of Negroes moved into Northern cities, escaping the segregation and discrimination of the south. Puerto Ricans also moved into the city in great numbers. In many New York City neighborhoods, whites moved out when their neighbors became increasingly darker skinned. But the people of East Tremont did not flee. More Negroes- doctors, lawyers, working men whose wives also wanted their families to have a better life -were coming into the neighborhood, some purchasing private homes, some moving into apartments. But East Tremont took into its bosom the newcomers with black faces as it taken in newcomers with white faces.

“People here were good with us,” said Charles Smith, one of the first residents in East Tremont. Cele Cohen remembered “My daughter used to walk to school with two Negro boys. We used to have Negro children over for dinner and they used to have my daughter over too.” A Puerto Rican influx began as well, and still no whites left because of it. It was a decent place for children of all backgrounds to live. It was a place for newcomers, whether from the Caribbean, the American South or Eastern Europe to assimilate and thrive.

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After-Reading Questions:

1. How does the author describe East Tremont? What kind of picture does Caro paint? Choose 1 quote from the text to support your answer.

2. Going back to our discussions from the beginning of the year, would you say this community had power? Why or why not?

3. Would you describe “East Tremont” as a neighborhood or a community? Explain your answer.

Name: _____

Text:

“Across from Bronx Park”

By Myra Shapiro

Annotations

We lived near the elephants
and a garden of roses
our parents arrived at
from work in sweatshops.
We climbed in the playground
and wandered like gypsies
on land not yet cleared
of forests and streams.
Women leaning out windows
watched as we left them-
they'd shout directions
for crossing the street.
From above they could see
both sides of the parkway
traffic had parted—
GONOWWATCHOUT!
Sitting in benches neighbors
argued for hours— *Freiheit!*
Forward! –from opposite camps.
When we finished playing
We'd ask and they'd watch us
cross Bronx Park East
back home again.
I'd get my friend Lola
who lived near me in 6C
to meet after supper
up on the roof—
and as we grew older
we'd scheme how to meet boys
at Loew's Paradise
on the Grand Concourse
the height of all going
no dreams went beyond.

A. What images does the author paint in your head?

B. What story does the author tell about the Bronx?